

WEST BENGAL ORIGIN

Labra

Mixed Vegetable Medley

The Harvest Dish of Bengali Pujas

AUTHENTIC RECIPE · STEP-BY-STEP GUIDE · PRINTABLE DIGITAL COOKBOOK

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Labra

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ABOUT THIS BOOK

Labra

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Nutrition values are estimates. Cooking times vary with equipment and ingredients. Readers with allergies or dietary restrictions should check every ingredient label before cooking.

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THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

The Dish That Feeds a Festival

Labra is Bengal's answer to the question every large communal kitchen eventually faces: how do you make a single vegetable dish substantial and interesting enough to feed hundreds of people at once? The answer is a medley — pumpkin, potato, eggplant, beans, and whatever else the season offers, all cooked together into one harmonious dish, most closely associated with the bhog (food offering) served at Saraswati Puja and Durga Puja across Bengal.

Its temple and puja-kitchen origins mean labra is traditionally prepared without onion or garlic, in keeping with the niramish style of cooking considered appropriate for religious offerings, relying instead on ginger, panch phoron, and a touch of sugar for its depth of flavor. The dish's genius lies in balance — no single vegetable dominates, and the combination creates a texture and flavor more layered than any one vegetable could achieve alone.

While deeply tied to religious festivals, labra has also found its way into everyday Bengali home cooking as a practical, nutritious way to use up whatever vegetables are on hand, carrying its festive origins into a far more ordinary, everyday role in many households.

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THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

The Dish That Feeds a Festival, continued

CULTURAL NOTES & OCCASIONS

Most closely associated with the bhog (religious food offering) served during Saraswati Puja and Durga Puja across Bengal, prepared in large communal kitchens. Traditionally made without onion or garlic, following niramish temple-cooking customs. A practical way to combine many vegetables into one cohesive, satisfying dish, both in festival and everyday home cooking contexts. Represents Bengali cuisine's skill at balancing many ingredients into a single harmonious dish rather than showcasing one dominant flavor.

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AT A GLANCE

Equipment & preparation

20m	30m	6	Easy
ACTIVE PREP	COOK TIME	SERVINGS	DIFFICULTY

Recommended equipment

- Large, wide kadai or pan
- Wooden spoon

STORAGE & MAKE-AHEAD

Labra keeps refrigerated for up to 4 days and, like many mixed vegetable dishes, holds up well to reheating. It freezes reasonably well for up to 2 months, though some of the softer vegetables may lose a bit of texture — still perfectly good for casual meals even if not quite as fresh-tasting as the day it was made.

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WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Ingredients

For the vegetables

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Pumpkin, cut into cubes	1½ cups	200 g	1½ katori
Potato, cut into cubes	1 cup	150 g	1 katori
Eggplant, cut into cubes	1 cup	120 g	1 katori
Flat beans or green beans, cut	1 cup	100 g	1 katori
Raw green banana (plantain), cut into cubes — optional	½ cup	80 g	½ katori
Radish, sliced — optional	½ cup	60 g	½ katori

For the seasoning

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Mustard oil	3 tbsp	45 ml	3 chammach
Panch phoron (Bengali five-spice blend)	1 tsp	3 g	1 chammach
Bay leaf	1	1	1
Dried red chili	1	1	1
Ginger paste	1 tbsp	15 g	1 chammach
Turmeric powder	½ tsp	1.5 g	½ chammach
Sugar	1½ tsp	6 g	1½ chammach
Salt	1 tsp	6 g	to taste

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WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Ingredients, continued

For the seasoning (cont.)

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Water	as needed	as needed	as needed

SUBSTITUTIONS & SOURCING

Labra is meant to be flexible — the specific vegetable combination varies by household and season, so feel free to include what's available to you: sweet potato, carrots, or cauliflower are all reasonable additions or substitutions within the spirit of the dish. Panch phoron is available pre-mixed at Indian grocers, or can be combined at home from equal parts mustard, fennel, cumin, fenugreek, and nigella seeds.

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STEP BY STEP · PART ONE

Preparing the Vegetables

01 CUT EVERYTHING TO SIMILAR SIZES

Cut all the vegetables into roughly similar-sized cubes, about ¾ inch / 2 cm, so they cook evenly together in one pot.



02 GROUP BY COOKING TIME

Set aside the faster-cooking vegetables (eggplant, beans) separately from the slower-cooking ones (potato, pumpkin, radish), so you can add them to the pot in stages.

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Preparing the Vegetables, continued

Chef tip. labra's charm comes from every vegetable being properly cooked, not mushy or undercooked — staggering when you add each one matters more than it might seem.

COOKING CHECKPOINT

Having your vegetables pre-sorted by cooking time before you start the tempering makes the actual cooking process move smoothly and helps prevent overcooked or undercooked pieces.

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STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

Cooking the Medley

03 TEMPER THE PANCH PHORON

Heat mustard oil in a large kadai and temper the panch phoron, bay leaf, and dried red chili until fragrant, about 30 seconds.

04 ADD GINGER AND THE SLOWER VEGETABLES

Stir in the ginger paste, then add the potato, pumpkin, and radish if using. Add the turmeric, stir to coat, and cook for 8–10 minutes, covered, stirring occasionally.



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STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

Cooking the Medley, continued

05 ADD THE REMAINING VEGETABLES

Add the eggplant, beans, and plantain if using. Continue cooking, covered, for another 10–12 minutes, stirring occasionally, until all the vegetables are tender.

06 FINISH WITH SUGAR AND SALT

Stir in the sugar and salt, and cook uncovered for a final 3–5 minutes to let any excess liquid reduce slightly.

Texture indicator. labra should be soft and cohesive but with each vegetable still identifiable, not cooked down into a single mash.

MISTAKE TO AVOID

Adding all the vegetables to the pot at once, regardless of their different cooking times, is the most common mistake — it results in some pieces mushy while others remain undercooked. Stagger the additions as described.

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SERVING & PAIRING

How to serve



Traditional Style

- Served as part of a bhog (temple offering) meal during Saraswati Puja and Durga Puja, alongside khichuri and other festive dishes.
- A common everyday side dish with rice and dal in regular home cooking.

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How to serve, continued

Restaurant Presentation

- Served in a bowl as part of a Bengali thali, showcasing the colorful mix of vegetables.

Family Style

- A large shared pot, practical for feeding many people at once during festival gatherings.

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RESTAURANT-GRADE TRICKS

Chef secrets

Getting the Balance Right

- Staggering when each vegetable joins the pot, based on how quickly it cooks, is the real secret to labra's success.
- A touch of sugar is traditional and important — it rounds out the dish without making it taste distinctly sweet.

Make-Ahead & Meal Prep

- Labra is genuinely convenient for large gatherings, as it can be made in bulk and holds well for hours on a warm stove.
- Pre-cut all your vegetables the night before a big cooking day to make festival-day preparation faster.

RESTAURANT TRICK

Some temple kitchens finish the dish with a small amount of ghee stirred in at the very end for extra richness — a nice touch for a special occasion version at home.

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BONUS CONTENT

Nutrition, variations & FAQ

APPROXIMATE NUTRITION, PER SERVING

140 kcal	3 g	20 g	6 g	5 g
CALORIES	PROTEIN	CARBOHYDRATES	FAT	FIBER

Estimates only; actual values vary with oil and portion size.

ALLERGEN GUIDE

Contains, based on the ingredient list: Mustard. Check packaged spices and asafoetida, which may contain wheat, and verify against your own ingredients.

REGIONAL VARIATIONS

Bhoger Labra	the traditional temple-offering version, strictly without onion and garlic.
Labra with Khichuri	served specifically alongside khichuri (a rice-lentil dish) for the classic puja meal combination.
Everyday Labra	a simplified home version using whatever vegetables happen to be on hand.

Can I use different vegetables than listed?

Yes — labra is traditionally flexible, and the specific vegetable mix varies by household and season. Use this recipe as a template.

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Nutrition, variations & FAQ, continued

Why are my vegetables unevenly cooked?

Likely all the vegetables were added to the pot at the same time. Stagger additions based on cooking time, as described in the instructions.

Can I make this without mustard oil?

Yes, though mustard oil contributes significantly to the dish's traditional flavor — a neutral oil is a workable substitute if mustard oil isn't available.

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REFERENCE

Ingredient glossary



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REFERENCE

Ingredient glossary, continued

GLOSSARY

Labra	a mixed vegetable medley, traditionally part of Bengali puja offerings.
Khichuri	a rice and lentil dish often served alongside labra during festivals.
Bhog	food offered to deities during religious observances, commonly including labra.
Panch Phoron	a Bengali five-spice blend used to temper many savory dishes, including this one.

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PRINTABLE RECIPE CARD

Labra

20m	30m
ACTIVE PREP	COOK TIME
6	Easy
SERVINGS	DIFFICULTY

VEGETABLES

Pumpkin	200 g
Potato	150 g
Eggplant	120 g
Flat beans or green beans	100 g
Raw green banana	80 g
Radish	60 g

SEASONING

Mustard oil	45 ml
Panch phoron	3 g
Bay leaf	1
Dried red chili	1
Ginger paste	15 g
Turmeric powder	1.5 g
Sugar	6 g
Salt	6 g
Water	as needed

METHOD

01 **Cut everything to similar sizes.** Cut all the vegetables into roughly similar-sized cubes, about ¾ inch / 2 cm, so they cook evenly together in one pot.

02 **Group by cooking time.** Set aside the faster-cooking vegetables (eggplant, beans) separately from the slower-cooking ones (potato, pumpkin, radish), so you can add them to the pot in stages.

03 **Temper the panch phoron.** Heat mustard oil in a large kadai and temper the panch phoron, bay leaf, and dried red chili until fragrant, about 30 seconds.

04 **Add ginger and the slower vegetables.** Stir in the ginger paste, then add the potato, pumpkin, and radish if using.

05 **Add the remaining vegetables.** Add the eggplant, beans, and plantain if using.

06 **Finish with sugar and salt.** Stir in the sugar and salt, and cook uncovered for a final 3–5 minutes to let any excess liquid reduce slightly.

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BEFORE YOU SHOP

Shopping list

☐ Pumpkin	200 g	☐ Potato	150 g
☐ Eggplant	120 g	☐ Flat beans or green beans	100 g
☐ Raw green banana	80 g	☐ Radish	60 g
☐ Mustard oil	45 ml	☐ Panch phoron	3 g
☐ Bay leaf	1	☐ Dried red chili	1
☐ Ginger paste	15 g	☐ Turmeric powder	1.5 g
☐ Sugar	6 g	☐ Salt	6 g

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